‘Has anyone here been to this helipad?’ a worried flight commander asked.

‘I have, Sir,’ I said, a few seconds after nobody answered. Suddenly, all heads turned towards me.

‘Gunjan, please tell the others about this helipad,’ he instructed.

‘Navigating to this helipad is quite challenging,’ I started. ‘The valley is quite confusing. There are too many turns and you cannot simply follow the bends of the river below you or the features around you to get there.’

Everyone listened to me quietly, even the flight commander. ‘No sortie is permitted to that helipad if the pilot and the co-pilot have not been there before. Even on occasions that either the pilot or the co-pilot has been there, the pilots have got confused. Their helicopters crossed the LoC and had to be directed back.’

‘So I guess Gunjan will have to switch then,’ one of the pilots said.

One thing was sure, and all of us knew it, that I would have to switch with the pilot who was scheduled to wait at the Srinagar airbase the next day for any contingency. There was nobody else among the eight of us who had been to this helipad in the Uri sector before. The flight commander’s sortie was an important one, so he couldn’t have gone with me for this casevac (casualty evacuation). The army had just captured Point 5140, the last objective on Tololing peak. And a VIP, who was supposed to visit there, was the flight commander’s passenger. So the next senior pilot, Wing Commander Joshi, was assigned as the captain of the casevac sortie. But the flight commander had still not said anything about my switching. For a moment I felt that he was concerned about sending a female officer to a mission so dangerous. His concern was valid, since he was responsible for my well-being.

‘Do you still remember the valley’s terrain?’ a concerned flight commander asked.

‘I remember, Sir,’ I said, trying to sound confident even when I was worried inside. ‘Don’t worry, Sir, I will not disappoint you.’

‘All right, so it’s decided. You go get some sleep. You have to take off at first light,’ said the flight commander, and went back to eating his dinner.